burning straw in strategic places to ensure the fire picks up quickly and evenly. As the heat builds, the kinsmen step back, fall into groups and watch the flames engulf the body. The Dom stays close, periodically using a bamboo pole to shift the wood, or the corpse, to aid the fire. Even from a few metres away, one might see the deceased's facial skin darken and melt under the heat.

When the corpse is significantly burnt, an important ritual called *kapal kriya* is initiated: the Dom positions a bamboo pole and invites the chief mourner to deliver a quick jab to the skull, breaking it and releasing the deceased's atman to continue its journey beyond or to finally merge with Brahman.

If a family can afford only the cheapest funeral package—or none, in which case they rely on government aid or charity—the corpse is burnt in stages on a small pyre: first the middle part burns and collapses, the head and the legs stick out until the Dom deftly pushes them in. It takes about 250 kg of firewood and two to three hours to incinerate a corpse. Near the end, the Dom uses a pair of tongs to extract a piece of hard tissue, usually from the remains of the chest or the hips, for the chief mourner to toss in the river, which the fish apparently nibble at. Then the chief mourner, his back to the pyre, flings over his head a small clay pot of Ganga water on the smouldering pyre. This symbolically ends the relationship of the living with the dead.

The Dom comes in next and douses the embers with more water. He gathers ashes and bone fragments in an urn, an act called 'picking flowers' (not bad for a euphemism). He clears the burning platform to make room for a new pyre. The kin take the urn down the ghats to empty it in the Ganga. Dom men wait with wire nets to receive this, hoping to find bits of gold from a tooth or a nose ring. All of this 'found' gold officially belongs to the Dom Raja. If a worker is caught pilfering it, he can be fired. But pilfering still happens, a young Dom tells me with a grin.

As the day progresses, discarded tinsel shrouds and bamboo biers pile up. Flowers, ash, plastic waste, unburnt wood, and muddy water accumulate around the pyres, giving it a shabby look. Cows, seemingly unfazed by the heat, try to get to the marigold flowers around the burning pyres, pooping wherever they wish. Each morning, municipal workers sweep all perishable waste into the river.